The Matching Myths

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The Mischievous Mothers

FAIRY TALE



Once upon a time, a boy came home and had double vision.

To his left was his mother, standing in the living room. But to his right, in the kitchen, stood his mother too!

"Take off your shoes, Tommy," said Mother One. Tommy started to obey.

"No, keep your shoes on love," said Mother Two. Now Tommy, uncertain, was frozen halfway.

What should he do? A good boy listens to his parents, true. But when he left home earlier today, he had only *one* mother. It must be a *fake*, yes, he thought of the other.

"Which one of you is my mom?" asked Tommy left and right.

"I am."

"I am."

Both mothers responded to his plight.

Even though both mothers looked the same, Tommy immediately *felt* which one was real. But he didn't *know* why, and hugging the wrong mother made him squeal.

"Well don't just stand there," said Mother One, "do your school exercises, dear."

"No, stay there love," said Mother Two, "or you will

slip on the wet floor, I fear."

He couldn't do both at once: stay *and* don't stay. But which one was his real mother? How do you recognize a face?

Well, Tommy thought, his real mother was of small size. Her hair was red and long, and she had large brown eyes.

@TODO: IMAGE; two mothers, side by side

But then he looked left and right, and saw this didn't help. There were *so many people* with red hair and brown eyes, he could even include himself!

"What's wrong with you, dear?" asked Mother One. "Come help me wash the dishes."

"You look great, love," said Mother Two. "Come to the kitchen and dine on baked fishes."

Another impossible command, so Tommy did nothing. This made both mothers angry, but where could he begin?

Well, he thought, his real mother often wore pink clothes. She had glasses and a pointy nose.

@TODO: IMAGE (mostly to break it up)

But then he looked left and right, and almost cried. There were *so many people* with glasses and pointy noses, this could not make him decide!

"If you don't come *here* now," said Mother One, "I won't read a bedtime story, boy!"

"If you don't come *here* now," said Mother Two, "I'm taking away your favorite toy!"

Tommy had to close his eyes; seeing two identical people made his sight blurry. Tommy had to cover his ears; hearing two opposite commands made him worry.

What made him recognize his mother? It wasn't superficial things, like hair, clothes or eyes.

It was the lines around her mouth, the unique way she would smile.

It was the voice like a singer, audible within a mile.

It was the odd way she held her hands, or made perfectly square sandwiches with jam.

All these tiny details, combined, said: this is who I am.

He would recognize his mother anywhere, and now he knew why. He knew which voice to follow, and which one was a lie.

@TODO: IMAGE => Final decision

Tommy went into the kitchen and hugged Mother Two. He enjoyed the food, didn't slip, but asked: "What did you do?"

The other mother took off her wig and the fake glasses over her eyes. It was his neighbor's mother! She was simply in disguise!

"We thought it would be a funny joke," she said with a grin.

"I'm just glad you still recognize me," said Tommy's mother, enjoying her win.

Ever since that day, Tommy never forgot the lesson. He'd think about the tiny things that made him able to recognize a person.

Until one day, to his delight, he could return the joke. He arrived home with a friend of his, who was dressed in Tommy's cloak. He had his mother worried slightly, but she wasn't fooled, oh no. She simply asked a question only Tommy would know!

And they lived happily ever after, solving every mischievous case. Until mother told him the story of the *Watchers of Face* ...

The Twin Tigers

Once upon a time, tiger twins were born.

Their parents cast a spell and placed the same toy in both their arms. A beautiful plush tiger, snuggly soft and very warm.

Two fluffy orange ears, pointing to the side. Four strong paws, two front and two behind. Whiskers so long you could tie them into knots. And a pattern of black stripes that, if you squinted, looked like dots.

@TODO: Image of the babies, clutching identical toys.

But that night disaster struck. An evil lion entered their castle, made no noise, and escaped with luck.

And when the sun rose the next day, one of the tiger twins was gone.

The years went by with a hole in Tigra's heart. She was surrounded by lovely animals, still she always felt apart. Where would her sister Felicia be? Would she be alright? Who came in and stole her, oh in that dreadful night?

Until one day, Tigra's heart seemed to finally break. She felt ill, she felt weak, not much more that she could take! And on that day her mother came, and explained the spell she cast: *As long as the twin toys are together, this day will never be your last.*

And so Tigra sent out a message, a call to every lord and dame. Have you seen this tiger toy? Only two were ever made, and they look exactly the same! And to thank you for the effort, Tigra promised a reward. A million gold for who brought the matching toy, which was all the money she stored.

Within a day, the first animal came. Lord Fallony of the Faraway Woods claimed he had a toy that was just the same! With a smile he showed a tiger, very fluffy and very warm.

@TODO: IMAGE?

But when Tigra looked closer, she saw the toy missed an arm! "This is not the one," she said. Feeling even more sick, she sent the Lord away. She didn't need to wait, for another animal came the next day.

Dame Frawt of the Misty Mills claimed she found the toy in the dirt. "It looks exactly like the drawing," she said, and Tigra believed every word.

@TODO: IMAGE?

But when Tigra picked it up, she couldn't even *see* its whiskers! "This is not the one," she sighed. "Another day I have to miss her."

The next day, Tigra could not even leave the bed. Clutching her own toy, she felt ill and sad. The next visitor was Merchant Monkey, who had to climb the tall stairs. "I have come to accept my million gold," said he, "for I hold the toy that comes in pairs!"

@TODO: IMAGE?

"Please leave my castle," Tigra said angrily. "This is not the one, I fear." When she turned the toy around, it was clearly missing an ear!

By now, Tigra had lost all vigor. It would seem every animal was only out to trick her! The real toy was missing,

and she had no clue. Until she realized the thing she had to do.

She had to build her own skill, to trust in her own eyes. She would look at *every* toy herself, and make her own judgement wise. Coughing and sniffing, she traveled through the lands. And she looked, and looked, and collected all toys that ever entered anyone's hands.

Until one night her fever rose high, and she felt she might not make it. All toys were thrown in a pile before her, and then she applied her wit.

@TODO: IMAGE?

"That's the one!" she croaked, pointing at the toy upside down. "Two ears, four paws, dots in fur and whiskers long!"

She matched the tiger toys, which started to glow, and immediately felt better. But she could never feel alright, not yet, until she had her answer.

She asked around to learn who had brought this toy. And when the sun rose, her fever broken, she jumped with joy.

Walking towards her was a tiger she would always recognize. That sly smile, those ears, those same royal eyes.

Felicia had been raised by lions, never knowing from whence she came. But when Tigra explained it, and the two magical toys were combined, she knew the twins were truly one and the same.

And they lived happily and well, protected by the magical matching spell.